CINEMA

HARD-HITTING DRAMA

Sandhya Suri's **Santosh,** ***about a woman constable in North India, is the UK's official entry to the 2025 Oscars in the 'Best International Feature Film' category***



Shahana Goswami in *Santosh;* (right) Sandhya Suri

Sandhya Suri has always "wanted to do what she wanted to". This headstrong attitude would see the British-Indian study mathematics in Germany, leave her home England for stints in Congo, Samoa, Japan and France, make two documentaries, and work with NGOs in India studying violence against women. The latter, along with an image of a female police officer facing angry Nirbhaya protesters in New Delhi, would inspire her first fictional feature, *Santosh*. Starring Shahana Goswami in the titular part, the Hindi film set in a fictional state in India is the UK's official entry to the best international film category at the Oscars and will have its India premiere in the South Asia section of the upcoming Mumbai Film Festival (Oct. 19-24).

Films on officials clad in khaki have mostly been larger-than-life, often action-heavy accounts, in which they are put on a pedestal, but when Suri started developing *Santosh* back in 2012 there weren't many being made on women cops. However, 12 years later, the landscape has changed with the *Mardaani* franchise featuring Rani Mukerji, a host of Hindi web series (*Delhi Crime*, *Aranyak*, *Dahaad*) and Deepika Padukone playing one in the upcoming *Singham Again*. Suri admits that as time lapsed in trying to get the script right, there were a few "let's give up crises", but what convinced her to not back down was that she hadn't seen a police procedural she fully believed in.

SANTOSH will have its India premiere at the Mumbai Film Festival (Oct. 19-24)

With *Santosh*, Suri tries to tap into the "terrible and interesting dilemma" of a lady officer as she starts investigating a girl's death and does so in an environment of intolerance, misogyny and caste bigotry. "For me, it's being credible in the details through a huge amount of research," she adds. "I can use that to push me to really make this feel so real than you are watching something unfolding before your eyes in a documentary-like way."

More than sisterhood, Suri says *Santosh* is her attempt to allow women "to have complex moral decisions to make" and to "show that they have quite complicated relations and it's not always solidarity".

Suri used the intervening decade to spruce up the script by taking it to the Sundance Directors and Screenwriters Lab in 2016 and getting the funding in place. The film was shot in peak summer in Lucknow last year with predominantly an Indian crew and featuring Sunita Rajwar (*Gullak*, *Panchayat*, *Stree*) as Santosh's boss. "The actresses were so humble and ready to work in such an honest manner without any diva-like requirements," says Suri, citing the film's small crew and budget.

While *Santosh* is her first feature, Suri has been engaged in filmmaking since she was a child growing up in Darlington. Her father, a doctor, was a passionate hobby filmmaker who'd make home videos documenting life in England for nearly four decades which he'd send home to Meerut. "We used to make films with him, spiral them, put them in a projector...it was very physical," says Suri, who would go on to use the found footage in her first documentary, *I for India* (2005). That film and then *Around India with a Movie Camera* (2018) and the BAFTA-nominated short *The Field* (2018) would further deepen her bond with India.

As Suri gets familiar with the legwork required to get *Santosh* in the Oscar shortlist, she is eagerly looking forward to have her film seen in India. "I want the cops to come and see it. I hope it doesn't feel condescending and over-explained to Indians. I hope I get it right," says Suri. The UK certainly thinks she has. ■

–Suhani Singh